police firing that killed two protesters at Behbal Kalan near Kotkapura, in Faridkot district. As Amritpal says: "Even after seven years, there is no justice." Official inaction means the radicals may be arrogating to themselves the role of judge, jury and executioner. On November 10, Pradeep Singh, an accused in the sacrilege cases, was gunned down in Kotkapura. Canada-based gangster Goldy Brar, also accused of orchestrating the murder of singer-turned-politician Sidhu Moosewala, claimed responsibility. The cops nabbed the shooters, but have not established a motive or link.

In retrospect, the whole trail seems marked by omissions and evasions. The Behbal Kalan Insaaf Morcha, which has been on a sit-in protest for over 400 days now, has demanded the resignation of Vidhan Sabha Speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan, the local MLA from Kotkapura who in the past was among the protesters. The Mann regime has been wary, almost inviting comparisons with the scenario painted earlier by AAP MLA and former IGP Kunwar Vijay Pratap Singh, who had alleged the two previous SIT investigations into the October 2015 police firing were aimed more at shielding politicians than nailing the culprits. "Two years ago, the Punjab and Haryana High Court had quashed my investigation into the Kotkapura incident. The Congress and Mann governments have also not pursued the case," he says.



**CHAIN REACTION** A protest by the Qaumi Insaf Morcha pressing for the release of Bandi Singhs

Even on inter-state issues, the Mann regime, after initial goof-ups, is perceived to be toeing the established line. Panthic voters are very sensitive on the issue of Chandigarh and feel strongly about Punjab—a Sikh-majority state—not having a capital of its own after losing its original capital, Lahore, to Pakistan. The overriding sentiment is that Chandigarh was built to compensate for this loss. Equally close to panthic hearts is the question of letting Punjab waters flow into the SYL canal. Radicals like Simranjit Mann or newbies like Amritpal keep stoking these sentiments. The AAP government is moving cautiously. In June last year, it allowed a Dal Khalsa protest march against Operation Blue Star and in support of the slain Bhindranwale. AAP leaders in Punjab say they believe in freedom of speech for everyone, but insist that violence will not be allowed. "Anyone indulging in violence has been booked and arrested," says AAP Punjab spokesperson Malwinder Kang. The party does have legislators from a panthic background, like Kultar Sandhwan, Gurmeet Singh Khuddian and Jaswinder Singh Ramdas. But unlike his predecessors Capt. Amarinder Singh and Badal, Mann, who comes from a Left background, has shown little interest in panthic politics.

Caution, however, is not helping the AAP regime escape the crossfire, like when the panthics demand the release of Sikh militants who remain lodged in Punjab and Delhi jails for decades now. "If India can release Rajiv Gandhi's killers, or the Bilkis Bano rape accused, why can't they release the Sikh prisoners?" asks Simranjit Mann. The list of 'Bandi Singhs', as they are called, has several names associated with the terrorism of the '80s-90s, including Rajoana. The father of his co-conspirator Jagtar Singh Hawara, Gurcharan Singh Hawara (see *The Panthic Faces*), floated the Qaumi Insaf Morcha, and has taken his protest to the Mohali-Chandigarh highway to seek the release of Jagtar and 21 others. Hawara Jr was anointed a parallel jathedar of the Akal Takht in November 2016. Although the SGPC is backing the protest, chief Harjinder Singh Dhami was roughed up on January 18 when he visited the protest site. It's a nightmare situation for the security agencies; if Hawara Jr is ever released, the radicals will move to make him the next Akal Takht jathedar, which may spread radicalisation further. The SGPC has set up an 11-member panel with leaders from all panthic factions to push for their release. The Badals, post their exit from the NDA, were also pushing to be part of the campaign, but several Sikh preachers, among them Baljit Singh Daduwal who wields influence in both Punjab and Haryana, saw it as a plank by a desperate Sukhbir to revive his fortunes.

## WHO'LL PLAY BOSS?

These days, panthic ire is also trained on the government in neighbouring Haryana. In December, the M.L. Khattar regime there constituted an ad hoc 38-member Haryana Sikh